

Creams

Making a cream involves combining oil or fat and water in an emulsion. If the process is rushed, the oil and water may separate. Unlike ointments, creams blend with the skin and have the advantage of being cooling and soothing while at the same time allowing the skin to breathe and sweat naturally. They can, however, deteriorate quite quickly and are best stored in dark, airtight jars in a refrigerator.

Small quantities of additional ingredients such as tinctures, powders, and essential oils can be added to a cream before or after it is put in jars. Adding an essential oil, such as 1 ml of tea tree (*Melaleuca alternifolia*, p. 112), to ½ cup (100 ml) of cream, counters mold growth and lengthens shelf life, as does 1 tsp (5 ml) of borax. Other recipes for making cream use infusions, tinctures, or infused oils.

1 Melt the emulsifying wax in a glass bowl set in a pan of boiling water, or a double boiler. Add the glycerine, water, and herb while stirring, and simmer for 3 hours.



2 Strain the mixture through a wine press or a jelly bag. Stir slowly but continuously until it cools and sets.

Standard Quantity

30 g dried or 75 g fresh herb, 150 g emulsifying wax, 70 g glycerine, and ½ cup (80 ml) water

Standard Dosage

Rub a little into the affected area 2–3 times a day.

Storage

Store in sterilized, airtight, dark glass jars in a refrigerator for up to 3 months.



3 With a small knife or spatula, place the set cream into dark glass jars. Tighten the lids and label. Store in a refrigerator as soon as possible.

Compresses & Lotions

Lotions are water-based herbal preparations such as infusions, decoctions, or diluted tinctures that are used to bathe inflamed or irritated skin. Compresses are cloths soaked in a lotion and held against the skin. Lotions and compresses are both simple ways to use herbs externally and can be very effective in relieving swelling, bruising, and pain, soothing inflammation and headaches, and cooling fevers.

After an accident or sports injury, bruising and swelling can often be reduced or prevented if a hot compress is swiftly applied, provided the skin is unbroken. Cold compresses are particularly useful in soothing inflammation, cooling fevers, and easing headaches. Both hot and cold compresses should be frequently soaked and reapplied for maximum benefit.

Applying a Lotion

As specified, make an infusion or decoction (see p. 291), and strain it well. Alternatively, dilute a tincture with water. Soak a clean cloth in the lotion and wring it out thoroughly. Then gently bathe the affected area with the cloth (rather than laying it on the skin as you would a compress).

Applying a Compress



1 Wash your hands thoroughly and soak a soft cloth or clean washcloth in the lotion. Wring out the excess liquid. Before applying, rub some oil on the affected area to prevent sticking.



2 Place the compress against the affected area. For pain and swellings, secure the compress with plastic film and safety pins and leave for up to 1–2 hours. Reapply as required.

Standard Quantity of Lotion

2 cups (500 ml) infusion or decoction, or 5 tsp (25 ml) tincture in 2 cups (500 ml) water

Standard Application of Compress or Lotion

Use as required. Prepare a fresh compress or lotion when it cools (if hot) or when it dries (if cool).

Storage

Store lotions in sterilized bottles, with lids, in a refrigerator for up to 2 days.